MOOD OF THE NATION

GEN Z

ANGER AND ANGST OF THE YOUNG

The MOTN survey finds the country's youth anxious for their future, with worries that they will be left behind and that the government is not doing enough. Policymakers would do well to heed their concerns

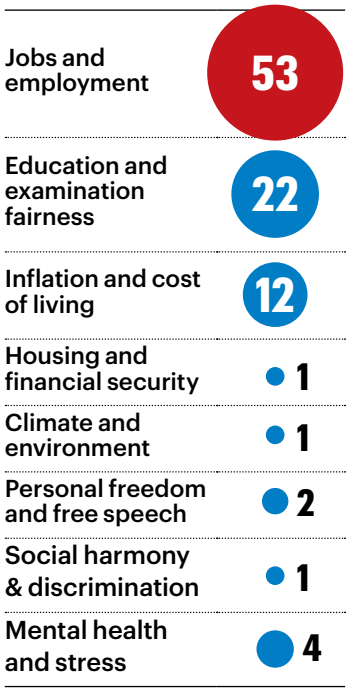
By **RAJ CHENGAPPA**

India's Gen Z is no longer a demographic that political parties can take lightly. Born between 1997 and 2012, they now constitute around 30 per cent of the country's voting population, giving them the heft to influence the political agenda and electoral outcomes. The exclusive INDIA TODAY-CVoter Gen Z survey, part of our biannual Mood of the Nation (MOTN) poll, reveals a generation that is ambitious but anxious, impatient with the status quo and worried whether the system will deliver the opportunities promised. Livelihood issues preoccupy them: 53 per cent say jobs and employment is the issue that matters most, ahead of education and examination fairness at 22 per cent, and of inflation at 12 per cent.

Every Indian should consider the implications of these survey findings, especially the fact that Gen Z is now filled with doubt that hard work will not be enough to get ahead in the country. Only 32 per cent believe merit and hard work matter most, while 26 per cent say money, connections and privilege count for more. Another 22 per cent believe there are just too few opportunities regardless of merit. In fact, 32 per cent cite the sheer shortage of jobs as the biggest problem, while 18 per cent complain of low salaries and 17 per cent say available jobs do not match their qualifications. Almost half—48 per cent—believe the Modi government's initiatives have not helped create more jobs.

Their aspirations tell a revealing story. Salary is the single most important consideration in choosing a career for 29 per cent, followed by job security at 19 per cent and work-life balance at 18 per cent. But the big downer is the continuing allure of a *sarkari naukri*: 49 per cent prefer government service, compared with just 16 per cent who want to start their own business, or the

Q. What issue matters most to you right now?



Rest DK/CS

Over 80% of Gen Z respondents are weighed down by thoughts of an uncertain future

Q. Which statement comes closest to your view on opportunities for the young in India?



59% of respondents feel AI will take away their job, or at least part of it